

the population of Bombay as mentioned in a timetable from 1941 (1,486,971 people) or a notice that the Frontier Mail no longer ran to the Ballard Pier station in Bombay because of uncertainty of sailings by steamers resulting from World War II.

The design

Timetables evolved over the years, encapsulating a diverse range of content, and graphic styles, and cover designs, which ranged from the very plain to elaborate full-colour illustrations. The style of the period is evident, for instance, on the cover of the Bombay, Baroda & Central India (BB&CI) Railway timetable of July–September 1945, which has an elaborate and prominent sketch of the Bombay Central railway station and a colourful bookmark promoting a film by the Hindi film director AR Kardar. Most other timetables, however, preferred a simple design.

General information

These booklets contained much more than train times and included lists of the railway's directors, managers, and members of local advisory committees. The October 1941 edition of the BB&CI timetable provided a list of dates on which various sections of the line were opened, and a calendar of fairs and festivals to encourage train travel. Also listed were dak bungalows, their distance from the stations and their rates. To encourage tourism, it also advertised attractive circular tour tickets around India. For instance, tour number 3 covered around 8,800 km for Rs 75.

Timetables also offered a peek into the world of the European traveller planning to travel in the railways' privately chartered carriages. The October 1942 edition of the Bengal–Nagpur Railway (BNR) timetable gave details and floor plans for the two tourist carriages it provided, while the BB&CI's December 1941 edition featured details of tourist carriages, along with 16 pages of tourist information on temples, tombs, and forts, and other sites. The illustrations depicted comfortable accommodation for those who could afford it. This feature, however, disappeared during World War II.

Dining and food